

Q&A

“We are still at the beginning of expansion in India”

Jean-Marc Pontroué, CEO of Panerai, speaks on India being one of the fastest growing markets for the Geneva-headquartered luxury watch brand

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

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PANERAI, THE luxury watchmaker that blends Italian design with Swiss technology, recently opened its third and largest boutique in India, in Mumbai. Another one is likely to open in Bengaluru soon. Jean-Marc Pontroué, CEO of Panerai, in a free-flowing conversation with Business Today, talks about why Panerai will not manufacture diamond watches, how smartwatches are a disruptor but in a good way, and a lot more. Edited excerpts:

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How important is India as a market for Panerai?

For us it [India] is one of the fastest-growing markets. We are still at the beginning of expansion in India. It's still a business that is polarised between Delhi and Mumbai. But over the next decade, it will be one of the most promising markets for the luxury industry in general, and for watches in particular. Panerai has been

present in India for many years now. We started with a boutique in a hotel some 13 years ago. We will continue to expand our retail footprint in key cities in India in the future.

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Will you be looking at multi-brand outlets?

Multi-brand is one of the potential facets of our

tinue to focus on the US and Europe or will Asia play a more important role?

The US remains the number one market for Panerai. But we have a good balance between Asia, Europe, and the Middle East. The brand has a strong position in some of these key markets. We are opening 45

is not really that we are prioritising any one region. We are just tracking all these business opportunities geographically to make sure that Panerai is present wherever lovers of luxury watches are living or travelling to.

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Do you feel that smartwatches are a disruptor

“SMARTWATCHES IS A FUNCTIONAL BUSINESS, WHILE OURS [LUXURY WATCHES] IS AN ASPIRATIONAL ONE”

expansion. It's not like we are purely in a mono-brand development scenario. We, however, believe that it is in key cities like Delhi, Mumbai, and Bengaluru, that our customers can best experience the brand's boutiques.

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Going forward, in terms of strategy, will you con-

new boutiques around the world this year. Our big flagship stores are called Casa Panerai. These are approximately 250 sq. m and spread over two floors. We are opening in New York, Milan, and Paris. We opened one in Sydney, another one in Amsterdam, and one in Taiwan. We will soon have another in Bengaluru. So it

for the luxury watch market?

Smartwatches are a great product and I'm not one of those in the watch industry who are afraid of such devices. Smartwatches are encouraging people to wear watches. Half of the people in the world don't wear watches. So, first, it is telling people that wearing watches is natural. Second,